



Preliminary investigation update

Rejected take-off and runway overrun, Tarlton Springs - Preliminary investigation update

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INVESTIGATION WORKFLOW SUITE

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Summary

On 18/06/2026, Saltbush Air SB512, a twin-turboprop registered VH-SBQ, was taking off from runway 09 at Tarlton Springs Aerodrome after dark with 44 passengers, 2 flight crew and 1 cabin crew on board. Two kangaroos moved onto the runway, the crew rejected the take-off, the aircraft struck the animals, and it came to rest 62 m into the 90 m runway end safety area. One cabin crew member reported bruising during the disembarkation and there were no serious injuries, but the aircraft was substantially damaged, two kangaroos were killed and the aerodrome closed for 4 hours 20 minutes. The investigation is examining how the animals reached the runway, the operator's arrangements for flying there after dark, the decision to reject the take-off and the stopping performance, and the question of the runway edge lighting remains open. The evening service is suspended, a runway inspection is now required before every departure there after last light, and the aerodrome operator has installed a temporary electric wire and programmed a fence repair.

What we know

On 18/06/2026, Saltbush Air SB512, a 50-seat twin-turboprop registered VH-SBQ, was the last scheduled sector of the day from Tarlton Springs Aerodrome. On board were 44 passengers, 2 flight crew and 1 cabin crew. It was the fifth sector of the crew's duty, added that morning when the rostered crew reported unfit. The doors closed at 07:16 UTC (17:16 local), 40 minutes behind schedule. The aerodrome was in darkness. The only runway inspection that day had been carried out before the first scheduled arrival, and it recorded the movement area as clear.

At 07:29:10 the tower cleared SB512 for take-off on runway 09 and passed the wind as 090 at 6 kt. Neither the tower nor the crew raised a runway inspection. The first officer was flying. Take-off power was set at 07:30:02. Both engines were matched and no caution or warning was recorded. The recorded wind gave a headwind of 4 to 6 kt throughout the roll.

The pilot in command called V1 at 07:30:29, at the calculated 112 kt. Two seconds later the first officer called "Roos - roos, roos, on the left". Two kangaroos were moving onto the runway from the northern side, past the 1,100 m point, at an estimated range at first sight of around 200 m. At 07:30:32 the pilot in command said "Stopping. I have control." and rejected the take-off at 118 kt, six knots above V1, with 695 m of sealed runway remaining. About one second later the aircraft struck the animals. The occurrence notification records that both animals were struck. The pilot in command's safety report records at least one. Two carcasses were later recovered, at 1,188 m and 1,221 m from the threshold. Maximum braking was established two seconds after the decision. Reverse was obtained on No. 1 only.

The aircraft left the end of runway 09 at approximately 21 kt at 07:30:51. It came to rest at 07:30:57, 62 m into the 90 m runway end safety area, upright and on the extended centreline, 28 m short of the end of the prepared area. There was no fire, and no evacuation was commanded. At the pilot in command's request, the tower activated the aerodrome emergency plan at 07:32:10 and a vehicle attended. Passengers left by the forward airstair. The notification records this as 4 minutes 8 seconds after the aircraft stopped. The airstair is heard operating at 07:34:40.

There were no serious injuries. One cabin crew member reported bruising during the disembarkation, and two kangaroos were killed. The aircraft was substantially damaged:

- three No. 2 propeller blades were beyond repairable limits
- the right main gear doors were distorted
- both right main tyres had deflated through the fuse plugs
- the lower right fuselage had two punctures.

The aerodrome closed for 4 hours 20 minutes. The evening Tarlton Springs service is suspended pending the outcome of the investigation.

What we are looking at

1. **How the animals reached the runway.** The investigation is examining the northern perimeter fence, its repair history and the aerodrome's wildlife arrangements. The fence was recorded as damaged in 04/2023, with animals seen passing through. Its repair was deferred at three budget rounds. An animal track through it was found at the 1,050 m mark, on the same side of the runway as both carcasses. The aerodrome falls below the size threshold in AS-139 10.4.2 that would require a documented wildlife plan.
2. **The operator's arrangements for flying after dark at Tarlton Springs.** The investigation is examining how the evening service was approved under CMR-2025-118. The current route risk assessment, RRA-041 issue 3, carries a daylight-only restriction, and that assessment was not reopened. The investigation is also examining why the operator's runway inspection requirement did not apply. That requirement applies only at aerodromes in Appendix 8A, and an aerodrome is listed only after a reported wildlife strike there. The aerodrome's own sighting log of kangaroos on the runway was not passed to the operator.
3. **The decision to reject the take-off above V1 (the speed after which the procedure is to continue).** This decision is being examined against the operator's procedures and recurrent training. Both crew members said their rejected take-off training has covered only aircraft system failures. The syllabus contains no scenario involving an obstruction on the runway.
4. **The stopping performance.** The investigation is examining the deceleration achieved against the scheduled figures. That includes the loss of No. 2 reverse thrust when the propeller struck the animals.
5. **Runway edge lighting.** Whether the brightness of the runway edge lights affected the crew's ability to see the animals has been examined. The available evidence could not resolve it, and it remains open.
6. **Wider matters found during the investigation.** These are being examined separately from the sequence of events. The first is the duty pattern on the evening rotation, which places the last sector late in a long duty. The second is the cabin floor emergency lighting, which was found partly dark after the occurrence. Engineering is checking whether the same component is affected across the fleet.

Containment and next steps

Interim safety action

- **Evening service suspended.** On 19/06/2026 the operator's Head of Flying Operations suspended the evening Tarlton Springs service. The suspension remains in place pending the outcome of the investigation.
- **Runway inspection now required at Tarlton Springs.** On 26/06/2026 the Head of Flying Operations issued temporary revision TR-2026-04, which adds Tarlton Springs to Appendix 8A of the Operations Manual. A runway inspection must now be requested before every departure there after last light. The take-off roll may not begin until the result has been passed. This is in place until a permanent amendment is made.
- **Perimeter fence.** The aerodrome operator installed a temporary electric wire on 25/06/2026. It has funded the northern boundary fence repair from its 2026 contingency and programmed replacement of the 140 m section for 09/2026. This work is still being implemented. [NOT ESTABLISHED: whether the fence replacement programmed for 09/2026 has been completed]
- **Recommendation to the operator.** The investigation has recommended that the operator:
 - list aerodromes in Appendix 8A on wildlife exposure rather than on a reported strike
 - require a route risk assessment for any aerodrome first operated into after last light.

A response was due by 30/09/2026. [NOT ESTABLISHED: the operator's response]

No interim action has been recorded on the cabin floor emergency lighting or on rejected take-off training.

Next steps

Engineering is establishing whether the same lighting component is affected across the fleet. The runway edge lighting question remains open. Before the final report is issued, the draft will be read by someone outside the investigation. The people and organisations it concerns will also be given the chance to correct matters of fact. Each safety action is still to be given an owner and a date. [NOT ESTABLISHED: expected date of the final report]

Distribution

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Figures



Figure 1: The northern perimeter fence at the 1,050 m mark, photographed on the site visit: the fallen section and the animal pad through it. Site inspection photograph SV-2026-0417-07, northern boundary at the 1,050 m runway marker, taken 23/06/2026